FREE GUIDE 02 · SENIOR-LEVEL JUDGMENT

‘Be More Strategic’: What to Do in Your Next Meeting

Translate vague feedback into a recommendation, a trade-off and a decision people can make.

‘Be more strategic’ is feedback. It is not an instruction.

In your next meeting, make the choice clearer. Show what matters, what cannot all happen at once, and what you recommend. You do not need a bigger presentation to start practicing judgment.

Start here

Choose one unresolved decision on your calendar this week. Write ‘We need to decide whether to…’ If your sentence describes a task list, keep going until the choice is visible.

01 Name the decision

02 Compare options

03 Own the trade-off

04 Set a review

Set aside 20 minutes. Work through the examples, then print page 4 for your own situation.

SEE IT IN PRACTICE

From a familiar response to a useful one.

Fictional examples for practice. Adapt the reasoning to the facts of your situation.

THE SITUATION

Before: We will try to deliver both requests this week.

After: The team has 30 hours available. The customer fix needs 20 hours and the internal report needs 20. Doing both needs 40 hours, so we must move scope, time or capacity.

The constraint is explicit. Working harder is not an unexplained source of ten extra hours.

THE RECOMMENDATION

Before: Which one would you like us to prioritize?

After: I recommend the customer fix this week and the full report next week. The fix addresses a current customer issue. The report supports a planning meeting that can move by three days. We can use the remaining ten hours for report preparation. Please confirm the planning meeting can move.

You compare consequences, make a choice and name the agreement needed from another team.

WHAT COULD CHANGE THE ANSWER

Before: We have made our decision.

After: If the report has a fixed regulatory deadline, the recommendation changes. We would need to narrow the fix or secure ten hours of qualified capacity. I will confirm that constraint with Finance today and review the plan tomorrow.

A recommendation becomes more credible when you can explain the evidence that would change it.

THE METHOD

Turn four familiar phrases into actions.

‘Be more strategic.’

Connect the choice to a business priority and a time horizon. Explain what the organization gains and what it gives up. Include the option of delaying or doing less.

‘Have executive presence.’

Begin with the recommendation. Then give the two facts that matter most. Pause for questions. Clear thinking and a calm explanation are more useful than performing certainty.

‘Think out of the box.’

Offer a credible different path: a smaller test, a changed sequence or a different constraint. Explain why it could work and how you would test it.

‘Show more ownership.’

Name the next action, owner, decision boundary and review date. Raise an obstacle with a proposed response, rather than waiting for it to become someone else’s surprise.

Keep this to hand

The decision is [choice]. We could [A] or [B]. Given [priority and constraint], I recommend [option]. The trade-off is [cost or delay]. I would change my mind if [evidence]. We will review [measure] on [date].

YOUR PRINTABLE WORKSHEET

Prepare one decision.

Complete this before the meeting. Aim for a recommendation you can explain in under a minute, with supporting detail ready.

01 The decision, its owner and the deadline

02 The business outcome and the constraint

03 Two credible options and the consequence of each

04 My recommendation and the trade-off I accept

05 What evidence would change my mind?

06 The agreement I need, next action and review date

TAKE IT INTO YOUR WEEK

One useful next move.

Before you use it

Read your completed sheet once. Check each statement below.

- ☐ This is a decision, not a list of activities.
- ☐ I have checked the constraints with the people affected.
- ☐ I can explain why I prefer one credible option.
- ☐ I have named uncertainty and a way to revisit the decision.

Try it once

Bring the completed sheet to one meeting. Start with the recommendation and ask, ‘Which assumption or trade-off do you see differently?’ Record what changed after the discussion. Better judgment includes revising your view when the facts change.

Afterward, ask yourself

Which question exposed a missing fact? What will I check before the next meeting?

Practice the choice before the meeting.

The Senior-Level Judgment Check uses six situations about decisions, priorities and ownership. Use your result to choose a skill to practice next.

Take the Judgment Check →

sayantannandi.com/tests/senior-level-judgment

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